ARIZONA

The Grand Canyon State



Tucson, Arizona, 1922. Monica Flin—a spirited young woman of French-Mexican heritage—opened El Charro Café in a converted Victorian house on Court Avenue in the heart of the Old Pueblo. She cooked the food of her family's northern Mexican traditions: Sonoran dishes built on flour tortillas, mesquite-grilled beef, and the mild, earthy flavors of the borderlands. Word spread quickly, and El Charro became a gathering place for Tucson families, politicians, and travelers passing through what was still a dusty, sunbaked desert town.

The story most fondly believed is that one afternoon a burrito slipped from Monica's hands and tumbled into a pot of hot oil. She bit back a Spanish expletive, substituting at the last moment the more family-friendly "chimichanga!"—a nonsense word, something like saying "thingamajig." The accidental deep-fry produced something extraordinary: a golden, shatteringly crisp shell wrapped around tender braised machaca beef, warm beans, and cheese.

The dish was entirely at home in Sonoran cooking. The cuisine of Sonora had long favored flour tortillas over corn, a tradition born from the wheat the Spanish planted in the 1600s, and its cooks had perfected the art of the burro—a large flour tortilla stuffed with simple, bold fillings. Monica's hot-oil accident simply pushed that tradition one delicious step further. El Charro stayed in the Flin family for generations, passed to her great-niece Carlotta Flores, and remains open on the same block today, its carne seca still dried under the desert sun on the rooftop.

What you are about to make is not a chain-restaurant imitation. It is the genuine article—built the slow way, with braised beef, simple spices, and a flour tortilla fried until it crackles at the touch. Serve it with a spoonful of fresh guacamole, a tangle of shredded lettuce, and a drizzle of crema. What arrives is border cooking at its most confident: a humble burro, worn ever since like something the desert invented on purpose.



SONORAN-STYLE CHIMICHANGA

Said to have been born in a Tucson kitchen in 1922, the chimichanga is Sonoran comfort folded, filled, and fried to golden Arizona perfection.

Yield: 4–6 chimichangas

INGREDIENTS

- 2 lb. beef chuck roast
- 1 small onion, chopped
- 2 cloves garlic, minced
- 1 tsp cumin
- 1 tsp oregano
- ½ tsp chili powder
- Salt and pepper, to taste
- 1 cup beef broth or water
- 4–6 large flour tortillas (burrito-sized)
- Refried beans (optional layer)
- Vegetable or peanut oil, for frying

ARIZONA-STYLE TOPPINGS

- Shredded cheddar or Monterey Jack
- Sour cream or Mexican crema
- Guacamole
- Chopped lettuce and tomato
- Salsa or enchilada sauce (some versions are "wet" chimis with sauce poured on top)
- Pickled jalapeños

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Make the shredded beef*: In a slow cooker or large pot, add the beef roast, onion, garlic, spices, and broth. Cook on low (slow cooker: 6–8 hours; stovetop: simmer 2–3 hours) until beef is very tender. Shred the beef with two forks and mix with some of the cooking juices. Set aside.
2. *Assemble the chimichangas*: Warm the tortillas slightly to make them pliable. Spread a layer of shredded beef in the center (and a bit of refried beans if using). Fold in the sides and roll up like a burrito, securing the ends.
3. *Fry the chimichangas*: Heat about 2 inches of oil in a deep skillet to 350°F (175°C). Carefully lower chimichangas into the oil, seam side down. Fry until golden brown and crispy on all sides (2–3 minutes per side). Drain on paper towels.
4. *Top and serve*: Serve hot, topped with cheese, sour cream, guac, and whatever else your Arizona heart desires. Optionally, pour warm enchilada sauce or salsa over the top for a "wet" chimichanga.